

world atlas that laid out instructions on charting the world with lines of latitude and longitude. It featured North Africa, India, Taprobane (Sri Lanka), and Sinae (China), including its capital, Chang'an.

Physical links

The transport networks of the ancient world were not so much constructed as evolved as common routes over millennia. In places, however, roads were cut deliberately by mobilizing forced labor. More often, a route was marked less by a physical road than by a maintained string of stages or settlements. States that expanded over wide areas needed to maintain regular communication by supporting these networks as a crucial aspect of their



Wealth of a caravan city

Petra was the capital of the Nabataean Arabs, who controlled the supply of luxury goods between Arabia and Mediterranean markets. The wealth of such a trade hub is evident in the surviving colonnades, temples, and tombs.

control. Roman skill in road-building grew as they gained control of Italy (see pp.106–07). Likewise, to send letters across their vast empire, the Persians developed a swift messenger system whose reputation for speed spread well beyond their empire. Xenophon, the Greek historian of the 4th century BCE, described relays of horses at stations spaced at one-day intervals and manned by officials. Whenever a letter arrived, the officials

immediately sent it on with fresh riders and fresh horses.

Imagining new worlds

The imagination was important in forming ideas of the world. Old tales of exploration were remembered by the next wave of adventurers. When Alexander's army (see pp.96–99)

After 400 CE, expansion of the world's horizons slowed until geographical knowledge was revived first by medieval Arab and Chinese explorers, then by Renaissance Europeans 250–53 >>.

ARAB EXPLORATION

New impetus for exploration, trade, and the communication of ideas was provided by the contacts created between the Atlantic and the Far East by the Arab conquests **174–77 >>.**

CLASSICAL WORLD VIEWS

Scholars relied on Classical views of the world for centuries after they were first produced. Both the **Peutinger Table** and **Ptolemy's world map 320 >>** continued to be recopied by scribes into the **medieval period**. Columbus **224–25 >>**

used Ptolemy's inaccurate calculation of Earth's circumference in attempting to sail west to India.

ARAB CARTOGRAPHY

The Muslim cartographer **Al-Idrisi** created a map for his patron, Roger II of Sicily, in the 12th century. Sicily was a contact zone between Muslims and Christians at the time. Al-Idrisi's map is oriented with south at the top, reflecting the outlook from Sicily toward the lands of Islamic rule. This map was one of the triggers for the pioneering Renaissance voyages that were to introduce the Old World to the New.



AL-IDRISI'S MAP

reached the edge of their known world, they imagined mythical heroes, such as Herakles, had explored the new horizon before them. The Greek historian Herodotus (see pp.102–03) wrote that the gold emerging from east of Persia was mined with the help of giant ants.

Nexus of trade

By c.1 CE, the world's trade routes had extended, through many intermediaries, from western Europe to China. China was largely self-sufficient, but imported desirable goods, such as spices from Southeast Asia and cavalry horses from Central Asia. Rome, in contrast, was a hub of commerce, dependent on trade. The empire imported food, slaves, animals, spices, silk, incense, and cotton.

